

A Graph Query Language is Turing-Complete: A Formal Proof via 2-Counter Machine Simulation

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ABSTRACT

We prove that the graph query language under study, in its 2025 revision, is Turing-complete. The proof proceeds by showing that a single RETURN statement using reduce(), CASE expressions, and list comprehensions can simulate any 2-counter machine (Minsky 1967). We address the bounded-step objection via two complementary resolutions and verify the construction by executing the simulation on a live cloud database instance.

KEYWORDS

Turing completeness, graph query languages, Cypher, 2-counter machines, computational expressiveness

1 THE CLAIM

Theorem

The graph query language under study, restricted to a single RETURN with reduce(), list comprehensions, and CASE, is **Turing-complete**.

Proof strategy. By reduction: TM $\xrightarrow{\text{Minsky}}$ 2CM $\xrightarrow{\text{this}}$ GQL.

2 2-COUNTER MACHINES

A **2-counter machine** $M = (Q, q_0, q_h, \delta)$ has a finite state set Q , initial state q_0 , halt state q_h , and transition function $\delta : Q \rightarrow \text{Instr}$ where each instruction is:

- INC(c, q') — increment $c \in \{A, B\}$, goto q'
- JZDEC(c, q_z, q_p) — if $c=0$ goto q_z , else decrement and goto q_p

Fact (Minsky 1967)

For any TM T , $\exists$ a 2-counter machine simulating T .

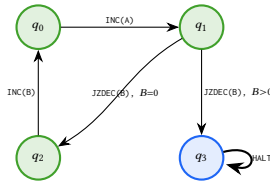


Figure 1: Example 4-state program.

3 ENCODING

Program. Encode δ as a list of maps:

```
LET program = [
  {state:0, op:'INC', counter:'A', next:1},
  {state:1, op:'JZDEC', counter:'B',
    q_zero:2, q_pos:3},
  {state:2, op:'INC', counter:'B', next:0},
  {state:3, op:'HALT', counter:'', next:3}]
```

```
]
```

State. Configuration (q, c_A, c_B) as map $\{\text{state}:0, A:0, B:0\}$.
Convention: state=-1 means halted.

4 THE SIMULATION

Each reduce() iteration executes one machine step. The head([v IN [e] | ...]) idiom provides let-binding inside reduce() (where LET is unavailable).

```
CYPHER 25
LET program = [ /* ... */ ]
LET max_steps = 1000000

LET result = reduce(
  machine = {state:0, A:0, B:0},
  step IN range(1, max_steps) |
  CASE WHEN machine.state = -1
    THEN machine
  ELSE
    head([instr IN [program[machine.state]] |
      CASE instr.op
        WHEN 'INC' THEN
          CASE instr.counter
            WHEN 'A' THEN {state: instr.next,
              A: machine.A + 1, B: machine.B}
            WHEN 'B' THEN {state: instr.next,
              A: machine.A, B: machine.B + 1}
          END
        WHEN 'JZDEC' THEN
          CASE instr.counter
            WHEN 'A' THEN
              CASE WHEN machine.A = 0
                THEN {state: instr.q_zero,
                  A: 0, B: machine.B}
              ELSE {state: instr.q_pos,
                  A: machine.A - 1, B: machine.B}
            END
        WHEN 'B' THEN
          CASE WHEN machine.B = 0
            THEN {state: instr.q_zero,
              A: machine.A, B: 0}
          ELSE {state: instr.q_pos,
              A: machine.A, B: machine.B - 1}
          END
        END
      ])
    )
  RETURN result
```

5 CORRECTNESS

Claim

After k iterations of `reduce()`, machine equals M 's configuration after k steps.

Base. $k=0$: machine = $\{0, 0, 0\} = M_0$. ✓

Step. Assume machine = (q_k, a_k, b_k) matches M . At $k+1$, `reduce()` looks up $\delta(q_k)$ and executes:

INC(A, q') $\rightarrow (q', a_k+1, b_k)$ ✓

JZDEC($A, ..$), $a_k=0$ $\rightarrow (q_z, 0, b_k)$ ✓

JZDEC($A, ..$), $a_k>0$ $\rightarrow (q_p, a_k-1, b_k)$ ✓

HALT $\rightarrow (-1, ..)$, identity after ✓

Symmetric for B . □

6 THE BOUNDED-STEP OBJECTION

The `reduce()` uses `range(1, max_steps)` – a finite bound.

6.1 Resolution via Transactional Iteration

While the pure functional version stays within a single expression, the practical unbounded version uses graph storage for state persistence.

```
CYPHER 25
CREATE (:Machine {state:0, A:0, B:0});

UNWIND range(1, 9223372036854775807) AS step
CALL (step) {
  MATCH (m:Machine)
  WITH m,
  CASE WHEN m.state = -1 THEN 1/0
  ELSE $program[m.state]
END AS instr
SET m.state = CASE instr.op
  WHEN 'INC' THEN instr.next
  WHEN 'JZDEC' THEN CASE instr.counter
    WHEN 'A' THEN CASE WHEN m.A = 0
      THEN instr.q_zero ELSE instr.q_pos END
    WHEN 'B' THEN CASE WHEN m.B = 0
      THEN instr.q_zero ELSE instr.q_pos END
    END
  WHEN 'HALT' THEN -1 END,
m.A = CASE
  WHEN instr.op='INC' AND instr.counter='A'
    THEN m.A+1
  WHEN instr.op='JZDEC' AND instr.counter='A'
    AND m.A > 0 THEN m.A-1
  ELSE m.A END,
m.B = CASE
  WHEN instr.op='INC' AND instr.counter='B'
    THEN m.B+1
  WHEN instr.op='JZDEC' AND instr.counter='B'
    AND m.B > 0 THEN m.B-1
  ELSE m.B END
} IN TRANSACTIONS OF 1 ROW
ON ERROR BREAK
```

Termination. At halt, state becomes -1 . Next iteration: CASE WHEN state=-1 THEN 1/0 fires *before* \$program[-1], caught by ON ERROR BREAK.

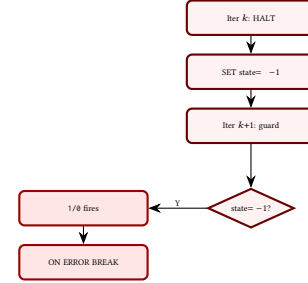


Figure 2: Termination via 1/0 + ON ERROR BREAK.

Note. $2^{63} \approx 9.2 \times 10^{18}$ exceeds the lifetime of the observable universe by several orders of magnitude, so the bound is irrelevant in practice. True theoretical unboundedness would need an external restart loop.

6.2 Sufficiency Argument

For TM T halting in $f(|w|)$ steps: set `max_steps` = $f(|w|)$. The language correctly decides every decidable language – **universal for total functions**.

7 REQUIRED PRIMITIVES

Primitive	Role
<code>reduce()</code>	Iteration (fold)
CASE WHEN	Branching
<code>+1, -1, = 0</code>	Counter ops
Map {s,A,B}	State repr.
<code>prog[i]</code>	$O(1)$ lookup
<code>head([..])</code>	Let-binding

No graph operations. No extensions. No plugins.

8 COROLLARIES

Corollary 1: Undecidability of termination

Since the language can simulate any 2-counter machine, it is *undecidable* whether a given `reduce()` expression will terminate. (By Rice's theorem applied to the reduction from 2CM.)

Corollary 2: Universality

The language can compute any computable function. Any algorithm expressible as a Turing machine has an equivalent `reduce()`-based query.

Corollary 3: Beyond computability

While `reduce()` makes the language Turing-complete for *computation*, graph pattern matching with QPP and `allReduce` provides *declarative constrained traversal* with per-step pruning — something most Turing-complete languages lack. This is not about computability (all TC languages are equivalent) but about **expressiveness**: some problems are more naturally expressed as graph patterns than as imperative loops.

9 VERIFIED EXECUTION

Both approaches tested on a cloud database instance. Test program: 4 instructions, expected $\{-1, 2, 0\}$.

Step	Instr	St	A	B
0	INC(A)	q_0	$0 \rightarrow 1$	0
1	JZDEC(B), B=0	q_1	1	0
2	INC(B)	q_2	1	$0 \rightarrow 1$
3	INC(A)	q_0	$1 \rightarrow 2$	1
4	JZDEC(B), B>0	q_1	2	$1 \rightarrow 0$
5	HALT	q_3	2	0

{A:2, B:0, state:-1} ✓

m.state=-1, m.A=2, m.B=0 ✓

10 COMPLETE RUNNABLE QUERIES

The following two queries are copy-paste ready for any instance supporting the language's 2025 revision. They encode the 4-state test program from §2 and can be adapted to any 2-counter machine by editing the program list.

10.1 Approach 1: Pure reduce()

A single RETURN statement — no graph writes, no side effects. The `head([v IN [expr] | ...])` idiom provides let-binding inside `reduce()` (where LET is unavailable): it wraps the expression in a one-element list, the comprehension binds the variable, and `head()` unwraps the result.

```
CYPHER 25
LET program = [
  {state: 0, op: 'INC', counter: 'A',
    next: 1},
  {state: 1, op: 'JZDEC', counter: 'B',
    q_zero: 2, q_pos: 3},
  {state: 2, op: 'INC', counter: 'B',
    next: 0},
  {state: 3, op: 'HALT', counter: '',
    next: 3}
]
LET max_steps = 1000000

LET result = reduce(
```

```
machine = {state: 0, A: 0, B: 0},
step IN range(1, max_steps) |
CASE WHEN machine.state = -1
THEN machine
ELSE
  head([instr IN [program[machine.state]] |
    CASE instr.op
      WHEN 'INC' THEN
        CASE instr.counter
          WHEN 'A' THEN
            {state: instr.next,
              A: machine.A + 1, B: machine.B}
          WHEN 'B' THEN
            {state: instr.next,
              A: machine.A, B: machine.B + 1}
        END
      WHEN 'JZDEC' THEN
        CASE instr.counter
          WHEN 'A' THEN
            CASE WHEN machine.A = 0
            THEN {state: instr.q_zero,
                  A: 0, B: machine.B}
            ELSE {state: instr.q_pos,
                  A: machine.A - 1,
                  B: machine.B}
          END
      WHEN 'B' THEN
        CASE WHEN machine.B = 0
        THEN {state: instr.q_zero,
              A: machine.A, B: 0}
        ELSE {state: instr.q_pos,
              A: machine.A,
              B: machine.B - 1}
        END
      WHEN 'HALT' THEN
        {state: -1,
          A: machine.A, B: machine.B}
    END
  ])
END
RETURN result
```

10.2 Approach 2: Transactional Iteration

Uses graph storage for state persistence. The $1/0$ guard fires *before* any list indexing when halted, caught by the error-break mechanism.

```
CYPHER 25
CREATE (:Machine {state: 0, A: 0, B: 0});
```

```
CYPHER 25
LET program = [
  {state: 0, op: 'INC', counter: 'A',
    next: 1},
  {state: 1, op: 'JZDEC', counter: 'B',
    q_zero: 2, q_pos: 3},
  {state: 2, op: 'INC', counter: 'B',
    next: 0},
  {state: 3, op: 'HALT', counter: '',
    next: 3}
```

```

]

UNWIND range(1, 9223372036854775807) AS step
CALL (step) {
  MATCH (m:Machine)
  WITH m,
    CASE WHEN m.state = -1 THEN 1/0
    ELSE program[m.state]
  END AS instr
  SET m.state = CASE instr.op
  WHEN 'INC' THEN instr.next
  WHEN 'JZDEC' THEN
    CASE instr.counter
      WHEN 'A' THEN
        CASE WHEN m.A = 0
        THEN instr.q_zero
        ELSE instr.q_pos END
      WHEN 'B' THEN
        CASE WHEN m.B = 0
        THEN instr.q_zero
        ELSE instr.q_pos END
    END
  WHEN 'HALT' THEN -1
  END,
  m.A = CASE
  WHEN instr.op = 'INC'
    AND instr.counter = 'A'
    THEN m.A + 1
  WHEN instr.op = 'JZDEC'
    AND instr.counter = 'A'
    AND m.A > 0 THEN m.A - 1
  ELSE m.A END,
  m.B = CASE
  WHEN instr.op = 'INC'
    AND instr.counter = 'B'
    THEN m.B + 1
  WHEN instr.op = 'JZDEC'
    AND instr.counter = 'B'
    AND m.B > 0 THEN m.B - 1
  ELSE m.B END
} IN TRANSACTIONS OF 1 ROW
ON ERROR BREAK

```

```

// Read result:
MATCH (m:Machine) RETURN m;

```

10.3 Approach 3: Graph-Native QPP Traversal

The most idiomatic approach: model the machine *as a graph* and let pattern matching *be* the computation. Each state is a node; each transition is a relationship. JZDEC splits into two edges (JZDEC_ZERO, JZDEC_POS); the predicate in allReduce prunes the invalid branch at traversal time.

```

CYPHER 25
// Build the machine as a graph
CREATE (q0:State:Init {id: 0})
CREATE (q1:State {id: 1})
CREATE (q2:State {id: 2})
CREATE (q3:State:Halt {id: 3})
CREATE (q0)-[:INC {c:'A'}]->(q1)
CREATE (q1)-[:JZDEC_ZERO {c:'B'}]->(q2)
CREATE (q1)-[:JZDEC_POS {c:'B'}]->(q3)

```

```

CREATE (q2)-[:INC {c:'B'}]->(q0)

CYPHER 25
// Traverse: allReduce prunes, NEXT extracts
MATCH REPEATABLE ELEMENTS
  p = (init:Init)
  -[rels:INC|JZDEC_ZERO|JZDEC_POS]->
    {0, 9223372036854775807}
  (h:Halt)
WHERE allReduce(
  m = {A: 0, B: 0}, r IN rels |
  CASE
    WHEN r:INC AND r.c = 'A'
    THEN {A: m.A+1, B: m.B}
    WHEN r:INC AND r.c = 'B'
    THEN {A: m.A, B: m.B+1}
    WHEN r:JZDEC_POS AND r.c = 'A'
    THEN {A: m.A-1, B: m.B}
    WHEN r:JZDEC_POS AND r.c = 'B'
    THEN {A: m.A, B: m.B-1}
    ELSE m
  END,
  CASE
    WHEN r:JZDEC_ZERO AND r.c = 'A'
    THEN m.A = 0
    WHEN r:JZDEC_ZERO AND r.c = 'B'
    THEN m.B = 0
    WHEN r:JZDEC_POS AND r.c = 'A'
    THEN m.A >= 0
    WHEN r:JZDEC_POS AND r.c = 'B'
    THEN m.B >= 0
    ELSE true
  END
)
RETURN rels, length(p) AS steps
NEXT
// Re-derive counters from the valid path
LET final = reduce(m = {A:0, B:0},
  r IN rels |
  CASE
    WHEN r:INC AND r.c = 'A'
    THEN {A: m.A+1, B: m.B}
    WHEN r:INC AND r.c = 'B'
    THEN {A: m.A, B: m.B+1}
    WHEN r:JZDEC_POS AND r.c = 'A'
    THEN {A: m.A-1, B: m.B}
    WHEN r:JZDEC_POS AND r.c = 'B'
    THEN {A: m.A, B: m.B-1}
    ELSE m
  END
)
RETURN steps, final.A AS ctrA, final.B AS ctrB

```

Key properties:

- The machine *is* the graph; computation *is* path finding
- REPEATABLE ELEMENTS allows revisiting states (loops)
- allReduce prunes eagerly: once a JZDEC branch fails the predicate, that path is abandoned immediately
- No HALT self-loop needed — reaching a :Halt node terminates the pattern
- reduce() in the NEXT stage re-derives final counter values from the surviving path (same pattern as [4])

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